

FIELD OF VISION SHARDA UGRA

A Story Called Sourav



Sourav Ganguly shouldn't mind this story being told. Last November, deep in exile from the national team, on a visit to Delhi, he was found still urbane and relaxed. Dressed in a crisp, white kurta-pyjama, wearing glasses with improbably stylish frames, he made jokes at himself. At how he was cast as Indian cricket's enemy No. 1. At what was being said about him. At being dispatched to play domestic cricket in grounds where sometimes they placed bricks in the nets because they couldn't find a set of stumps for the man who had been captain. He was content to be bad boy of the moment and philosopher king at the same time.

Tea was drunk and the usual gee-up things that are said to cricketers in strife were said, including the wish that he go out and score "several" centuries. The word seemed to surprise Ganguly. "Several?" he echoed with an arch smile and then explained how he saw the issue of any possible comeback. "You're picking me on form," he said, utterly sure, "not ability."

At the time, it seemed an outrageous contention. Ganguly was several light years away from making his way back into the team. His brief four-match county stint had been a let-down, he had performed fitfully in first-class cricket, his recall seemed based more on the collective hopes of Bengal rather than messages from the team management in South Africa then.

But what do we know?

Today, 12-odd months from that afternoon, everyone in Indian cricket cannot fall over themselves enough, cannot stop falling over him. In acknowledgement, in apology, in explanation, in waves of we-are-not-worthy. We stumble around in confusion, saying, 'But we...' 'but you...'

For the first time, Ganguly has crossed 200 in a Test innings—in his 99th Test. For the first time he will score 1,000 Test runs in a year. He plays like the man who, with the wealth of his experience, has been returned the gifts of his youth. He goes to Australia as India's best batsman of the year and it is a title he will not relinquish easily.

On that afternoon in late 2006 his sangfroid about what needed to be done seemed misplaced. But an athlete's self-image is a key component of his game, no more than with Ganguly who wears his strengths and flaws like a tight T-shirt. Then, in the middle of changing equations and shifting sands, there was only one constant in Sourav Ganguly's rather wild life: he knew who he was.



SAURABH SINGH

Photographs by SHANKAR



Pillai



Mani



George



Jacob

Mergers of Convenience

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM As a party, the Kerala Congress, which represents the interests of the state's Christian community, has split as it has grown and grown as it has split. Formed in 1964, the party has broken up six times and at last count, there were five different factions named after an individual—KC (Mani), KC (Pillai), KC (Jacob), KC (Joseph) and KC (Secular). Last week, four factions, all constituents of the Congress-led United Democratic Front, decided to sink their dif-

ferences and work together before merging. "Our ultimate aim is the merger of all factions and the ouster of the Marxist-led Government," said P.C. George, leader of the faction named after—who else—himself. But there is a hitch. The KC (Joseph) group is in alliance with the Marxists and though its leader was stripped of his ministership on allegations of molesting a woman on board a flight, he still swears by the Left. For now, at least.

by Rupesh Paul

Topping the News Charts



DELHI Aaj Tak was judged the Best Hindi news channel at the Indian Television Academy Award for the seventh time in a row. A few weeks ago, Aaj Tak had won the

Indian Telly Award for best news channel. Speaking on the occasion, TV Today Chairman and Managing Director Aroon Purie said, "It is a proud moment for Aaj Tak and the TV Today team. Winning the award for seven years in a row reflects Aaj Tak's leadership position and shows us the faith that viewers and the industry have reposed in us." Aaj Tak has also been successfully launched in the US, the UK and Europe.